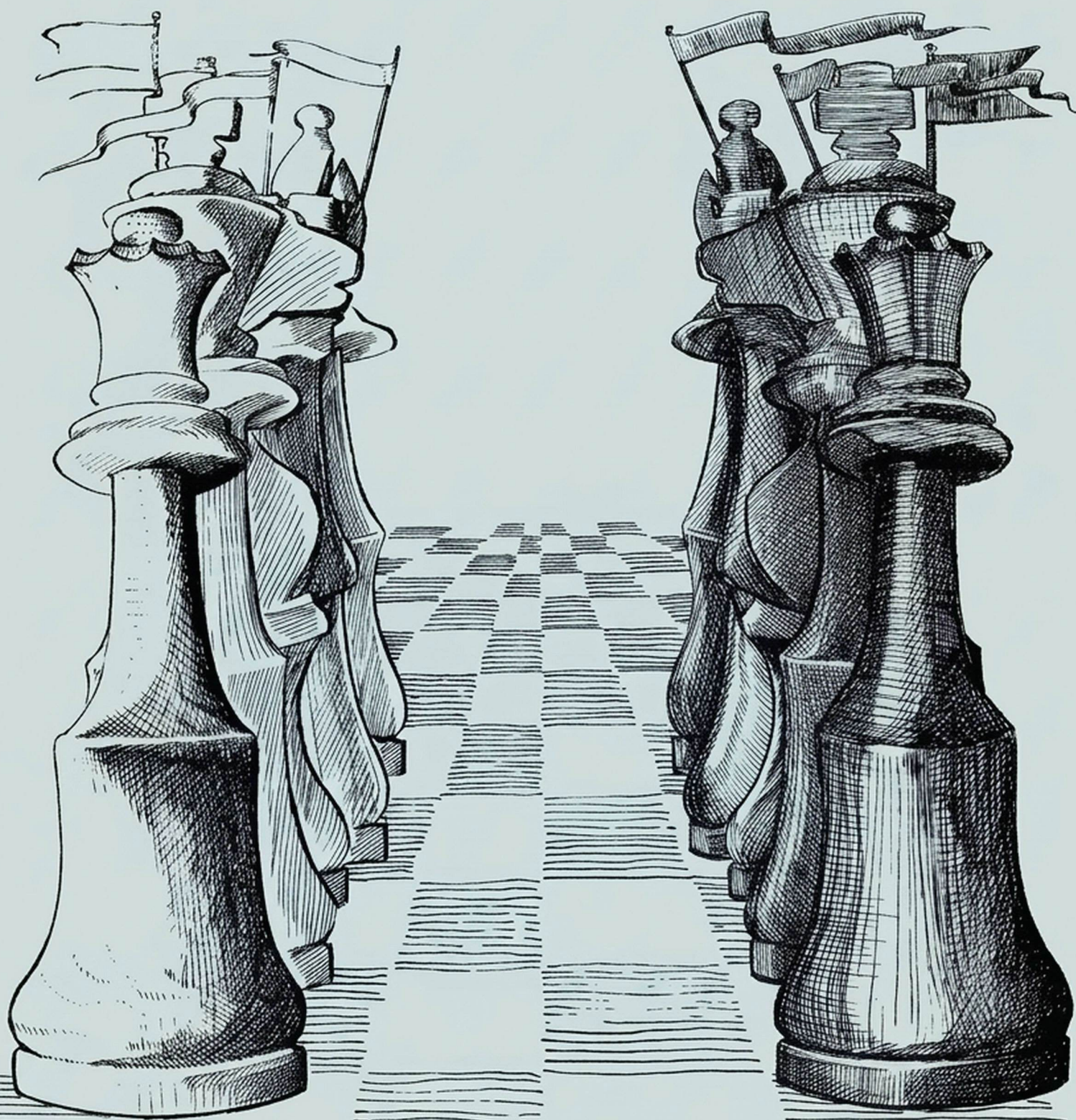


POPULAR CHESS

No. 7



EDITORIAL from the Editor, Michael Basman

I shall begin this magazine with two apologies- first for the late arrival of this issue due to my teaching chess in various schools. As a result the job of writing articles tends to get pushed aside until the term ends. All the same, Popular Chess, and its predecessor, Rabbits Review, does not try to be topical except in its computer articles. So the materials in Rabbits Review No 1 are just as relevant as anything printed today. If your appetite for the magazine is not sated by its occasional appearance, are you sure you have read all the back issues?

Numbers 1-12 of Rabbits Review are available at 70p each post free, and Nos. 13-21 of Rabbits Review as well as Popular Chess 1-6 cost 90p each.

My second apology is to John Tayler, inventor of Tayler's variation discussed in the last issue. John Tayler was a Leicester player, not to be confused with the U.S. master Jim Tayler. Unfortunately, John recently committed suicide, but hopefully his name will live on among the ranks of fascinated chess players.

This issue contains details of the Grand Open POSTAL tournament, starting later this year. Many of our subscribers are already keen postal players, belonging to the Stars Barred Postal Club, run by Francis Hynes of 104 Circle Court, Barton Road, Stretford, Manchester M32 9GJ. If you have never tried postal chess, I can recommend it as an exciting pastime, which also helps you to study positions deeper.

The chess training scheme is well under way, and over 100 people have obtained their bronze badge, and 8 people - Steve Hampton, Pat Armstrong, John Blaikie, H. Ward, Lolla Izzard, Daniel Starling, Peter Starling, and Xerxes Mistry - the Silver. The Gold, which takes a player up to the 100 grade, will be written I hope this summer vacation. If you would like details of this scheme, which trains players from beginner to club level, write to the address below.

POPULAR CHESS is published several times a year. The subscription is £5 for six issues. Back issues cost 90p each post free from Audio Chess, 7 Billockby Close, Chessington, Surrey KT9m 2ED. Make cheques payable to Audio Chess.

HOLIDAYS IN CASSWELL BAY. Sea and sand in Britain's outstanding area of natural beauty. Very reasonable accommodation a brick's throw away from the beach. Write to Rosa Bruton, Casswell House, Casswell Bay, Swansea, Glamorgan, Wales.

MYERS OPENINGS BULLETIN seems to be going from strength to strength, no doubt gaining encouragement from the demise of other more glossy publications. I have stocks of all 33 issues produced so far, at 75p each, and can take six issue subscriptions for £4.50. Each magazine is a goldmine of enjoyable opening analysis, which will provide you with a lot of surprising opening weapons as well as helping you to enjoy your games more, instead of wondering whether you are following the 'correct

Grandmaster continuation'. Myers is also really good on historical articles, as well as allowing several standard openings to creep into his pages.

BACKS TO THE WALL!

by Ian Josephs

The British only fight when they have their backs to the wall, so they say ... certainly when I look at some of my games I find an alarming number where I have lost when I had a clear winning position partly compensated however by a few where I came back from a hopeless position to storm home the eventual winner.

Chess psychology must account for some of it - i.e. all players of club status tend to relax when winning and a lot of us also get fighting mad and play our best chess when hopelessly losing.

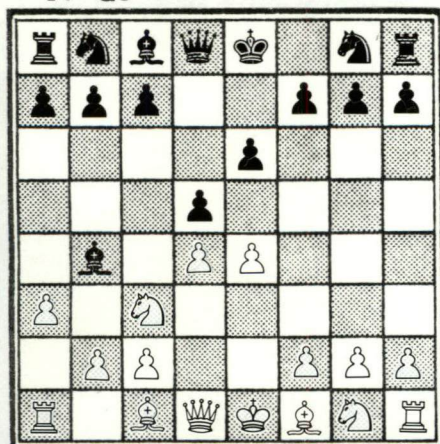
I'll give you an example of each from two of my games in a recent tournament in the hope that the Editor might be able to help me toughen my mental attitude when he sees what I still do in spite of all my learned articles for Rabbits.

JOSEPHS V. STYPHALIADIS (in France)

(I played this one at his house and arrived in pouring rain to be set on by a huge Doberman Pinscher 'puppy-dog' (so he said!) who playfully nipped my ankles and refused to let me near the front door until squawkings and tentative "Good boy then"s attracted the attention of my opponent five minutes later. This knockout tournament is played in Black's private house and is played every fortnight - not bad especially if you're a dog lover.

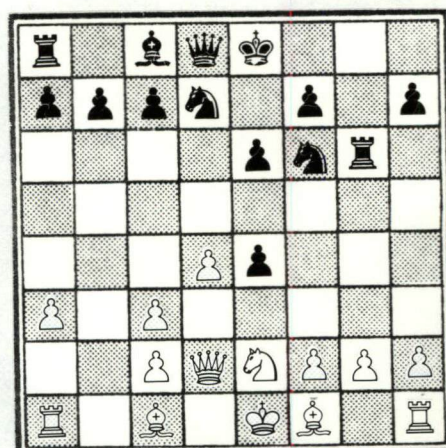
Somewhat unsettled I accepted a cup of tea (was it drugged?) and began.

1. e4 e6
2. d4 d5
3. Nc3 Bb4
4. a3



I like this line though nobody else does except a young Yugoslav who beat Fischer with it some years ago - unfortunately he was black!

4. ... Bxc3+
5. bxc3 dxe4
6. Qg4 Nf6
7. Qxg7 Rg8
8. Qh6 Rg6
9. Qd2 Nd7
10. Ne2

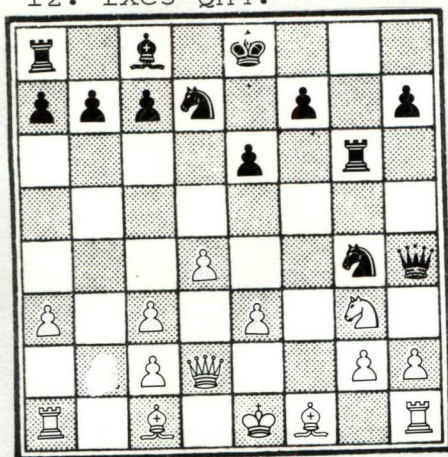


All 'book' up to here but then he played 10. ... Ng4 (instead of b6 or c5 or Qe7) 11. Ng3?? I played automatically because the usual plan for white is then to play Be2 and 0-0 but note from my foul up gentle reader ALWAYS LOOK TO SEE WHAT YOUR OPPONENT WILL DO NEXT - EVEN IN OPENINGS YOU THINK YOU KNOW WELL. I forgot this one and even if I had remembered it I would probably have missed his next stroke.

11. ... e3!

How can you spot this sort of thing?)

12. fxe3 Qh4!



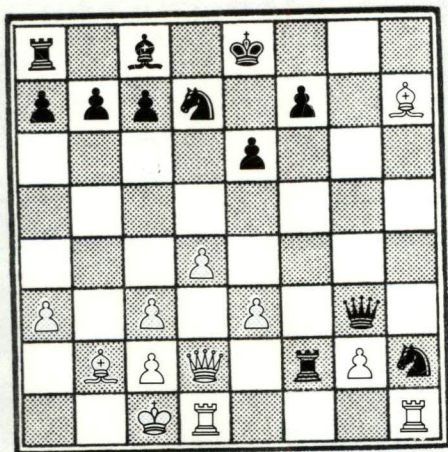
Threatening .. Nxh2 and then ... Qxg3 and mate not too far off if I'm careless - I pondered awhile ... quite a long while in fact! thinking about Bd3 and/or Kd1 but I am just not well suited to a dour defensive game in a lousy position (who is?) - the only try for counterplay I reckoned was to develop rapidly and throw everything but the kitchen sink at the black king. So looking (but not feeling) confident I played

13. Bb2(!?) Nxh2
14. 0-0-0 Qxg3
15. Bd3 Rf6

I'm a piece down but my rooks are connected (see previous issues of P.C.) and I can maybe open up before he can consolidate, so

16. Bxh7 Rf2

Rook on the 7th already - he must have been reading my previous article in Popular Chess about it!



17. Qd3 Nf6
18. Be4 c6

(So he can develop his bishop and

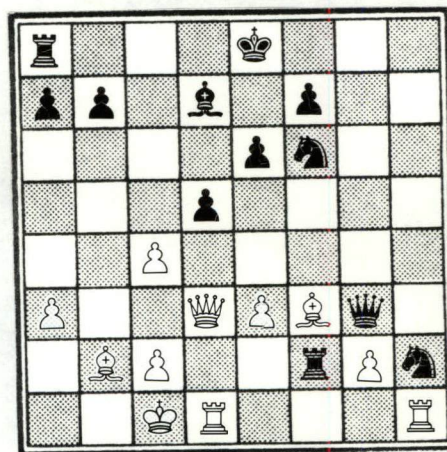
castle afterwards)

19. Bf3 (shuts in his rook or lets in my rook if he exchanges)

19. ... Bd7
20. d5!

I've GOT to attack or I'm lost

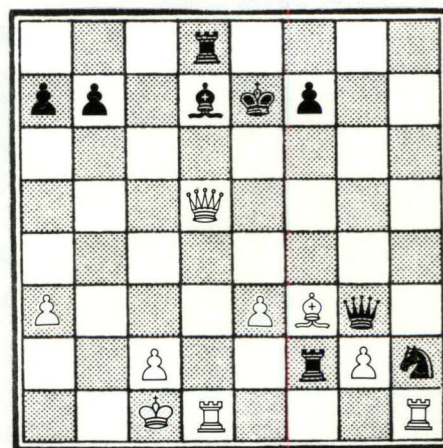
20. ... cxd5
21. c4!



This move opens up to diagonal of my bishop at b2 and threatens to demolish his central barricade. Things are looking up!

21. ... Ke7 (to protect the knight)

22. Bxf6+ Kxf6
23. Qd4+ Ke7
24. cxd5 exd5
25. Qxd5 Rd8?

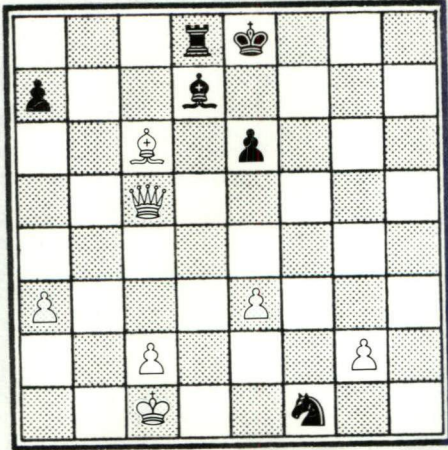


Gets his rook into play but I prefer Qc7 or something similar.

26. Qc5+ Ke8
27. Bxb7 Qg7
28. Rd4 (stops Qa1 mate) Rf1+
29. Rxf1 Nxf1
30. Bc6!

He must lose something here ...

30. ... Qf6?
 31. Re4+ His queen in fact! Qe6
 32. Rxe6 No messing fxe6



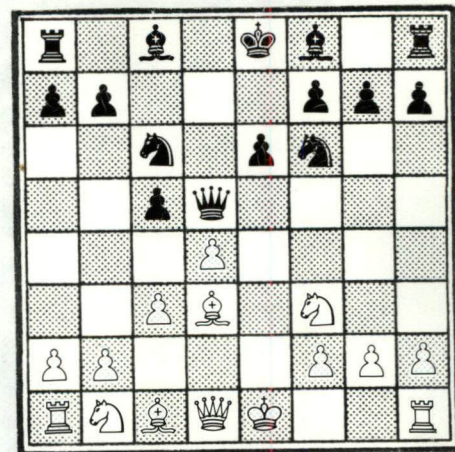
33. Bxd7 (swap off when 'up')
 33. ... Rxd7
 34. Qe5 Ke7
 35. Qc5+ Kf6?? He's lost anyway
 but hoping for a blunder from me he
 makes another himself
 36. Qb5 Rd5
 37. Qxf1+ Ke5?? allows
 38. Qf4 MATE

So I left opponent and dog thoroughly cowed but I felt (a) I should not have got into that mess in the first place - so why did I? (I didn't like your opening, which only loses time with the queen and develops black's rook as well as giving him a strong central pawn at e4 - Ed);
 (b) I was lucky to win so how did I? (After black won the piece he did not develop and consolidate but instead continued the momentum of the attack with moves such as 16. .. Rf2, when 16. .. Nb6 and Bd7 would have been better. After white's 20. d5! and 21. c4! he had got counterplay against the exposed black king - Ed.)

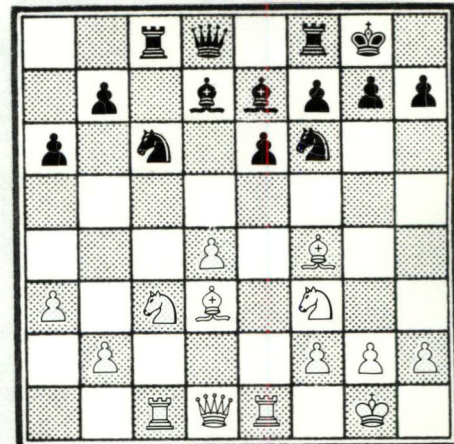
Now a second game, where the reverse occurred. I am still wondering how I got knocked out of this tournament in only the second round by an opponent about my own level who nearly resigned before I made my blunders.

JOSEPHS V. PELORI

1. e4 c5
 2. c3 d5
 3. exd5 Qxd5
 4. d4 e6
 5. Nf3 Nf6
 6. Bd3 Nc6

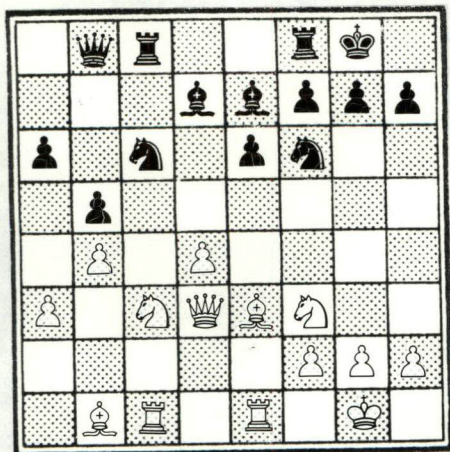


7. 0-0 cxd4
 8. cxd4 (Unlike some computers I know, Mr. Pelori will NOT I am sure fall for 8. ... Nxd4?? 9. Nxd4)
 8. ... Be7!
 9. Nc3 Qd8
 10. Bf4 a6 (to stop Nb5)
 11. a3 (same sort of reason!)
 11. ... 0-0
 12. Rcl Bd7
 13. Rel Rc8



Both of us develop in 'classic' style, with rooks on open files and knights centralised etc. but I reckon I have a 'space advantage' and prospects for a king side attack .. so

14. Bb1 b5
 15. b4 Qb6
 16. Be3? Looks clever but it was probably better on its h2-b8 diagonal
 16. ... Qb8 Takes possession
 17. Qd3 Try to force a weakening



17. ... h6? Success beyond my wildest hopes .. g6 is better for him.

18. Ne4 Nxe4

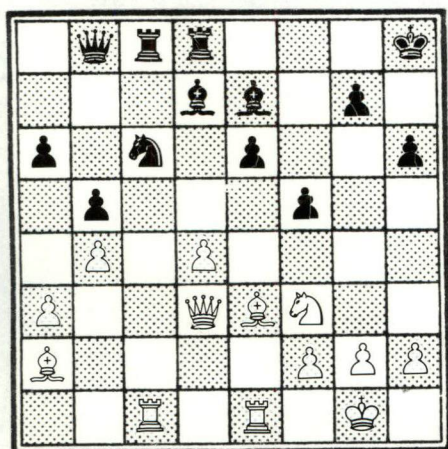
19. Qxe4 f5 Weak but obligatory to fend off disaster

20. Qd3 Rfd8?

Centralises the rook on his semi-open file BUT allows the bonecrusher

21. Ba2 (threatening Qxf5 and menacing his weak e pawn as well)

21. ... Kh8



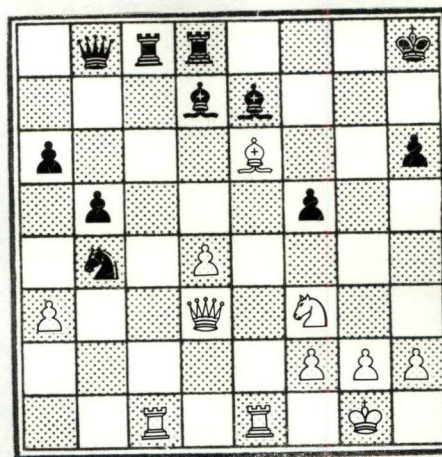
At this point I reckon all my pieces are active - his king side is weak but given time he can consolidate if allowed. So I play the flashy

22. Bxh6!

I can't calculate all the variations - my brain just won't cope when I try - but at the least I will pick up 3 pawns (e, f and h) for the piece and have a draw by perpetual check whenever I wish against a slightly stronger player ...

22. ... gxh6

23. Bxe6 Nxb4!



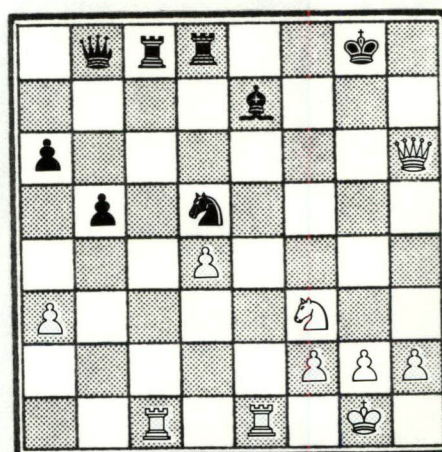
A resource I had not foreseen. I consider 24. Rxc8 which after a general swap off leaves me a pawn up (I think) plus a better position all round but excited by mating prospects I play

24. Qxf5 which is probably even better - or is it?

24. ... Bxe6

25. Qxe6 Nd5

26. Qxh6+ Kg8



His king is completely NUDE and for my sacrificed bishop I also have 3 connected passed pawns (f, g and h) surely enough to win?

27. Qe6+ I'll see if I can tempt his king out into the middle when it is actually safer in the corner!

27. ... Kh8 I can't!

28. Qh6+ Kg8

Here my greedy self says grab material with Qxa6! but my chess conscience says "No - never go pawn grabbing when you could be better employed activating your pieces". Next time I'll listen to my greedy self because material up to a club

player is money in the bank and positional advantages are often mirages (in my case anyway).

29. Qg6+ Kh8
30. Rcd1 hang onto my pieces
30. ... Rd6
31. Qh5 Kg8

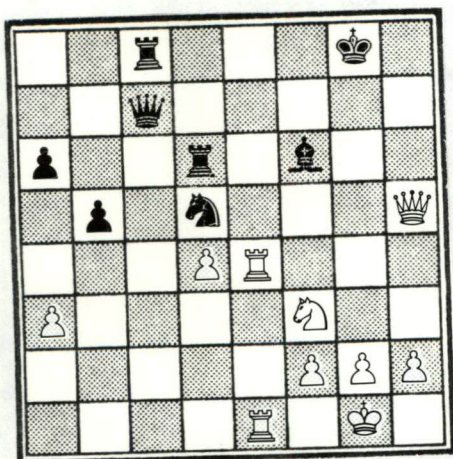
I first considered Ne5 threatening Qf7 and if Rf8 then Ng6 winning at least the exchange. However I reasoned that a rook is a more powerful piece than a knight so I tried for a quick mate with

32. Re4? allowing
32. ... Bf6

which covers a lot of vital squares for him.

33. Rdel surely this will squeeze him to death? but no

33. ... Qc7



I suddenly got a bit windy about back rank mates if I play Re8+ Rxe8 Rxe8+ as although it looks very good it leaves me open to Qcl+ unless I take a breather and play h3 and that might let him get in an impregnable defensive position ... I don't know.

(Editor's comment: there are positions where attacking play and sacrifices are justified, and experience helps to recognise when the enemy king is sufficiently exposed, and our attacking force is adequate. Here, with queen rook and knight against king white should have enough. It's just a question of working out the little details as we go along. After

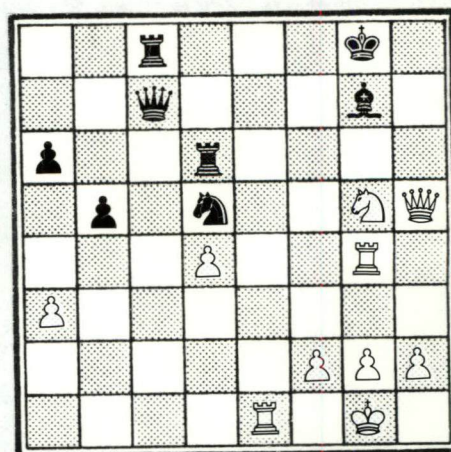
34. Re8+ Rxe8
35. Rxe8+ Kg7
36. Qh8+ Kg6
37. Rg8+ white is bound to get a strong attack, e.g.
37. ... Kf7
38. Qh7+ Ke6
39. Qe4 Kf7

40. Qe8 mate.)

I'm rapidly getting demoralised as his pieces all seem very active now so I try

34. Rg4+ Bg7

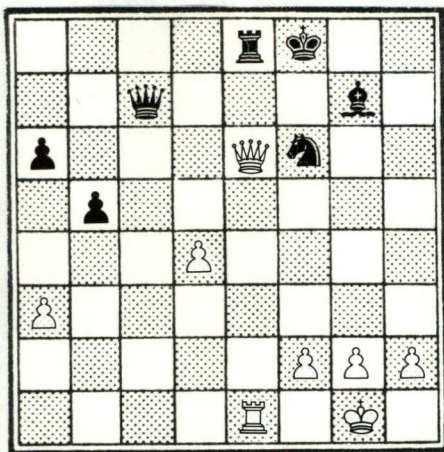
Here I forgot my Golden Rule - PFCC - look for possible pins, forks, checks and captives, both for him and for 'y ou' before moving. I was still 3 passed pawns for an immobile bishop so why get so flustered and overlook the menace of black's Nf6? I still wanted MATE with a capital M and reckoned I'd better activate my knight by Ne5 which was probably quite OK - but then I changed my mind because I wanted to be as near the enemy king as possible and played 35. Ng5?? the losing move ...



35. ... Nf6! forking my rook and knight, and covering h7 and e8 to boot!

Bemused I abandon good chances of a draw (Qh4 or Qh3) and play all too swiftly 36. Qg6?! unwilling to give up the attack despite the obvious

36. ... Nxg4
37. Qh7+ Kf8
38. Qf5+ Nf6 and his knight is safe.
39. Ne6+ still believe it or not bent on attack
39. ... Rxe6!
40. Qxe6 Re8!



and I lose my queen OR get mated
OR resign like the gentleman I am.
How did it happen? Help me
Mr. Editor and maybe help others
at the same time.

THE EDITOR COMMENTS

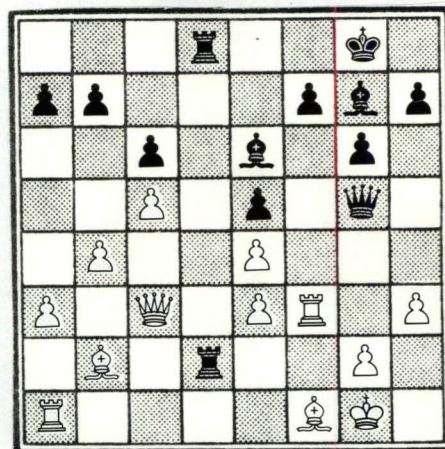
The problems of rapid changes of fortune beset nervous players in particular. Conducting a pell-mell king side attack, with the time on your clock inexorably evaporating, places extreme demands on a player's self-control. I used to be very prone to blunders at the end of games which would otherwise have been masterpieces, but increasing age tends to give greater stability.

You can also make a conscious effort to retain stability if you recognise that an adverse situation is developing.

Taking an analogy from boxing, a boxer is in a far worse situation than a chess player. The boxer may have only a few seconds to right himself, but a chess player, having made a terrible mistake, still has time to recover himself and resolve to play on and make the best of a bad position. It is important not to waste time and energy in self-recrimination, which does not help during the game, and should be eliminated as much as possible after a game. Of course after a heavy defeat one always suffers from 'post-loss depression' (PLT) but with practice this can be got over in a few hours.

An example of how not to behave when things go wrong comes from the

game Basman - Kinlay, Manor Tyres 1980:-



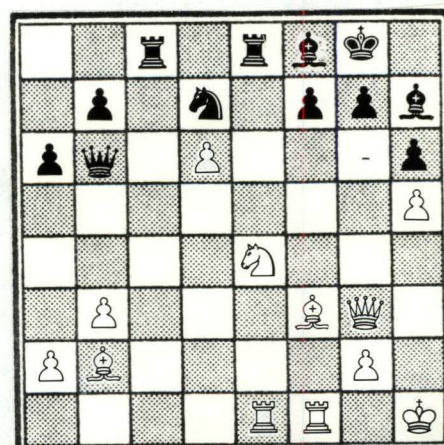
I had had a grizzly position all the way through, and the black rooks now totally dominate the central d file. Kinlay decided to finish me off with 1. ... Rd8-d3!?

This brilliant sacrifice only works if I take the wrong way with 2. Bflxd3 allowing 2. ... Qg5xg2 mate. Instead, however, I gave up my queen for two rooks by 2. Qc3xd3! Rd8xd3 3. Bflxd3

Dismayed by this turn of events Kinlay made another error, and later even resigned in a position which was far from clear. Then he stood up, enraged with himself and tore up the score sheet.

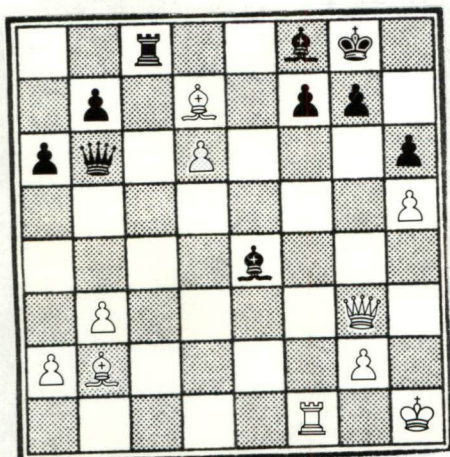
Naturally, though a very talented player, Jonathan never made the IM title and now has a steady job with an insurance firm...

Resilience when you have made a cock up is worth developing and can frequently turn round dodgy positions in your favour. I remember this example from the ARC Masters 1983:



White against the young master J. Branford, I had met stubborn resistance, but thought I had finally cracked it with

1. Bg4 Rxe4
2. Rxe4 Bxe4
3. Bxd7



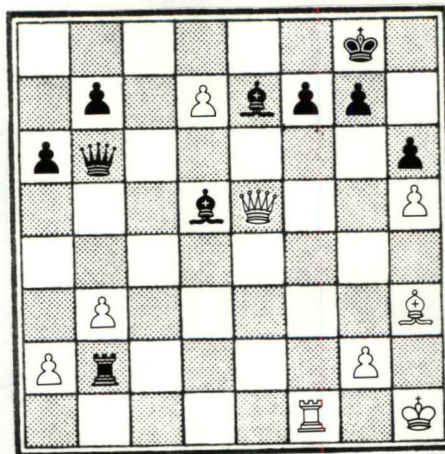
White has got his attack going but he must make it stick otherwise black will capture his advanced d pawn and obtain the advantage. I was expecting something passive like 3. ... Rd8, after which I had prepared the stupendous finish 4. Be6!! Qxd6 (4. ... fxe6 5. Rxf8+!) 5. Rxf7!! (queen sacrifice) 5. ... Qxg3 6. Rxc7 dcl ch! Kh8 7. Rg8 dcl ch! Kh7 8. Rh8 mate

However, Branford had no intention of being so obliging and simply played 3. ... Rc2! a horribly strong move which threatens both the bishop at b2 and the pawn at g2

Reluctantly I realised I'd have to jettison my brilliant mate and the bishop at b2 as well. However, though a piece down I thought I might have some swindling chance if I kept the passed d pawn on the board, especially as we were approaching the time control.

The game continued:

29. Bh3 Rxb2
30. Qf4 Bd5
31. d7 Be7?
32. Qe5!



Black blows it and allows a deadly fork on three pieces, the rook at b2, bishop at d5 and bishop at e7. After 32. ... Qc5(?) it was all plain sailing:-

33. Qxb2 Qb5
34. Re1 Be6
35. Qd2 Kh7
36. Qc2+ Kg8
37. Rxe6 fxe6
38. Bxe6+ Kh8
39. Qc8+ 1-0

After the game I decided that 3. Bxd7 had been wrong and I should have played 3. Be6 straight away.

Being able to play well in time trouble is not one of my skills, so I generally recommend players to avoid running short of time. You'll no doubt answer that "I can't help it". Here there are two types of players, those who persistently get into time trouble because they cannot make up their minds, and those who are now and then impelled into time shortage because the game is very tough and it threw up some unexpected difficulties at a critical point.

The players who are persistent time trouble victims need to train themselves with a clock so that they are moving at a general rate of 2-3 minutes a move, which should keep them within the time limit. This change of pace will at first seem artificial to them, and they may find that they are going to the opposite extreme and gradually accelerating their speed of play to lightning proportions. But with practice, and accepting that there will be early failures, you can learn to play at a more even pace.

When in time trouble though, one tip is to concentrate twice as hard as you would normally do and become more determined not to let slip a silly blunder. A game of chess takes a long time - 4 to 5 hours often, and naturally the degree of attention and effort one puts into it varies from time to time. But with only say five minutes on the clock, you need to take yourself in hand, be very determined not to lose control and make wild moves. It is very noticeable that in time trouble players will try for quick spectacular wins and tactical strokes which may not in fact be what the position requires. You need to move quickly but not wildly.

THE MAGICAL MYSTERY TOURNAMENT

The 3rd Grand Open C.C. Tournament of the British Postal Chess Federation fell somewhat short of "Grand" last year when it failed to attract enough entries and was postponed until 15th October 1984. Entries are now invited again for this highly original and extremely well organized three round knock-out tournament open to players living in the British Isles. There is no qualification for entry and the fee of £7.50 payable to B.P.C.F. may be sent to the Tournament Organizer, R.Gillman, 85 Hillyard Road, London, W7 1BJ. Simply give your name and address clearly in block letters and enclose an S.A.E. if you would like an advance copy of the rules and a receipt.

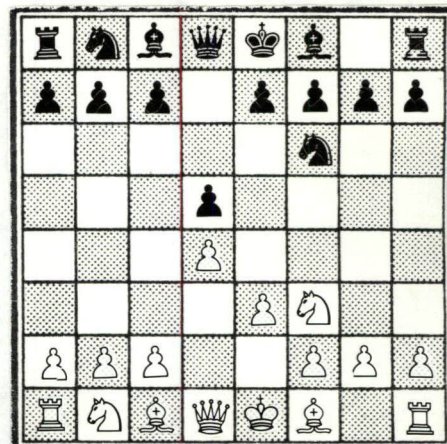
There is an unusually high element of chance built into this tournament. Entrants are placed by lot in sections of up to 100 competitors who play one game against each of ten opponents simultaneously. Pairings are made by an arithmetical system known as the Silli System after the inventor, a Dr. Silli of Italy. It has also been called the "Very Silly System" by unlucky entrants who draw an unusually high proportion of strong opponents! The system provides ten games to each competitor, five with white and five with black, in such a way that no competitor has the same ten opponents. Normally, each competitor has only one or two opponents in common with any other. The 20% best scoring competitors from Round One qualify for Round Two and 15% from Round Two qualify for the Final. There is a surprise consolation cheque for many of the Round Two competitors who fail to qualify for the Final. The Tournament Secretary has £300 to distribute at his discretion. Suspense is maintained throughout the tournament because the score needed to qualify for the next round is never certain until all the results are in.

A 60-page booklet "The First Grand Open" by Gillman and Hawkes is available. It contains a fine selection of 84 games in the English Descriptive notation, mostly annotated with 75 very clear diagrams, a short introduction, tables of results and an index to openings and players. The price is £1.50 [post free in UK and Europe] payable to R.Gillman and sent to him at 85 Hillyard Road, London, W7 1BJ or Giro A/C No. 53 551 9303.

CONSIDER THE COLLE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. e3

The Colle System is a little backwater variation of the Queen Pawn Openings, far less popular than the sophisticated variations arising from 1 d4 and 2 c4, which lead into Queen's Gambit Systems as well as modern defences like the Grunfeld, King's Indian, Nimzo-Indian and Benoni.



The Colle has not even established itself as the current 'alternative' line to the Queen's Gambit - that role was usurped by the ascent of the Torre, Queen's Bishop Attack and Veresov lines, which though similar in structure to the Colle, have one important difference, that the white queen's bishop is developed early, and not left semi-buried at c1, hoping for eventual release by e3-e4.

Yet for the club player, the Colle System has great advantages. It is the sort of opening you can play against almost anything (ah, he says and whets his lips - less work). Its strategy is simple and accords to the Classical principles of development. Against routine play it can end in an explosive king side attack. Against good defence, it can give a slight advantage and often a favourable endgame position. The important thing is not to play it in too stereotyped a fashion; the very fact that it is a universal weapon often makes its users a little lazy, and they do not try to alter their moves to counter unusual replies. This mechanical approach often leads to bad positions, which in turn gives the opening an undeservedly bad name.

In my opinion the Colle is a fully viable system, even at master level, giving rise to many interesting and unique positions, yet still being simple enough for success at the club. Between the wars it was a very popular master's opening, which was the time Colle himself was playing it. His fellow Belgian, George Koltanowski, took it up and was very successful with it. Later Koltanowski emigrated to the USA and wrote a book on the Colle system, explaining its ideas, and giving many of his own and Colle's games against the best players of the day.

This present article is based largely on Koltanowski's book, an entertaining but rambling affair. I hope it will give you enough confidence and understanding to try the line yourself, and later you may want to extend your knowledge by reading the book (advertised at the end of the article).

Classical opening theory asks you to develop your pieces in the centre, but realises that you cannot do this if the pieces do not have pawn protection; and secondly that the more valuable pieces have to be developed further back still to avoid enemy harassment. If we had some 'battle plan', it might look something like this

4th row	1st layer	P	P	P	P	pawns, least valuable
3rd	2nd layer	P	B	N	B	bishops and knights
2nd	3rd layer	P	R	Q	R	major pieces
1st	4th layer			K		king

Actually, most opening systems will not lay out their pieces in exactly this way. But the design of many of them can be traced to this formation.

Take the Classic Queen's Gambit.

		P	P				
		N	B	P	N		
P	P	Q			P	P	P
		R			R	K	

In the main we have the pieces stacked up behind the pawns, and the major pieces stacked behind the minor pieces. If we look at some of the more modern systems, we notice a kind of recession away from the centre by the pawns, and as a result the pieces need to take up even deeper positions than before.

Instead of moving the pieces as quickly as possible to the fourth row, the modern systems will often develop all pieces on three rows, and only after completing development will then seek further expansion. The piece most altered in its positioning is the bishop. The rooks and queens always occupied backward posts in the early stages of the game; and the knights, once developed on the second or third row, would not be moved again for fear of breaking that other positional principle - move each piece once in the opening. But the bishops used to flash out immediately to the third and fourth row alongside their pawns. However, with the advent of limited or backward centres, bishops could not be so gainfully employed, and their more restrained development coincided with the increase in popularity of the fianchetto formation, where the bishop was placed on knight two (N2) (to use the descriptive notation) and used its long range to strike all the way across the board.

Where does the Colle system fit into this picture of opening play? It is a Classical system, emphasising central control, development, king safety, yet it differs from other Classical systems in not being immediately expansionist. The Colle places one pawn on the fourth row, not two, and then completes its development around a basic pyramid structure in the centre. If you compare this with the Queen's Gambit, Giuoco Piano, Ruy Lopez, Open Sicilian, you can see that in these systems the white player either places two pawns on the fourth immediately, or intends to do so without the slightest delay. But to the Colle player, this sort of activity would stretch his resources. Instead he says "I will only take what territory I can command easily. If I capture too much territory with my pawns too early on, all my efforts will be bent upon defending this territory, and I may not have time to complete my development."

The Colle System then, after playing a pawn up to d4, and another to e3, then mobilizes and masses behind the e3 pawn and seeks to push the e3 pawn a step further to e4. In this advance is held the success and failure of the system. Because though there is a gain in making a long prepared for advance, there is also a loss of time involved in having moved the pawn twice to reach the e4 square.

Due to its modest initial appearance, are we to classify the Colle as a 'modern' (or hypermodern) system of the type described earlier? I think not. In the first place a pawn is from the very first move placed in the centre, at d4, and unlike systems such as the Grunfeld Defence, strenuous efforts are made to maintain it there.

In the second place the bishops are not fianchettoed, and one is placed squarely at d3, where it often shows quite primitive and aggressive designs upon the enemy king position. Thirdly, there is no intention of ceding the opponent's superiority in the centre, and allowing him to place his pawns there, with the intention of later attacking and undermining his central position. The Colle permits equality in the centre at first, but after about move seven or eight white having castled will try and acquire the lion's share of the centre.

Let us now look more specifically at the ideas and early moves of the Colle System.

The first move will be 1 d4 and black will answer either 1 ... d5 or 1 ... Nf6, or possibly 1 ... f5. When the Colle was 'invented' it was regarded as imperative to stop the follow up 2 e4.

White's second move will be Nf3, and then his intention is to continue with e3, Bd3 and 0-0.

Meanwhile black will as likely as not have advanced a pawn to c5 and this white answers by moving his own pawn to c3. As white intends to later advance his pawn from e3 to e4, he gives his d4 pawn additional support to avoid its liquidation. Finally white brings his knight from b1 to d2, to put an additional attack on the e4 square, and we might reach a position like this.

So far white has followed many of the standard rules of development. He has pawn control of the centre.

He has castled.

He has moved each piece only once.

The one deviation from the classical systems is the bishop at c1, which has made no effort to come off the back row, and in fact looks far worse off than it was at the beginning of the game.

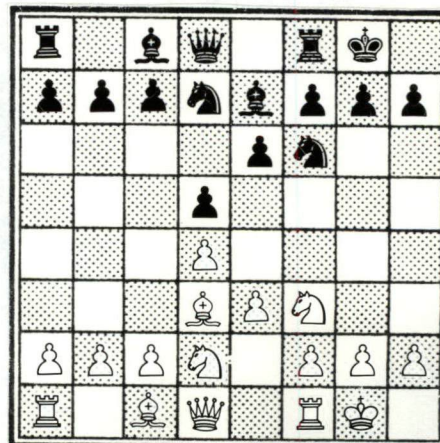
Since development is said to be when all the pieces have departed from the back row and rooks are 'connected', we might expect white's next new moves to be Qe2 or Qc2, and b3 followed by Bb2. However, white's plan is different and he intends to release his queen's bishop by the advance of the 'e' pawn.

Let us look at an example game where white achieves this plan unhindered by the opponent. Our sample will be from the output of the master himself - Edgar Colle.

Played at Hastings in 1928.

White E.Colle Black V.Buerger

1. d4 Nf6
2. Nf3 d5
3. e3 e6
4. Bd3 Be7
5. Nbd2 0-0
6. 0-0 Nbd7

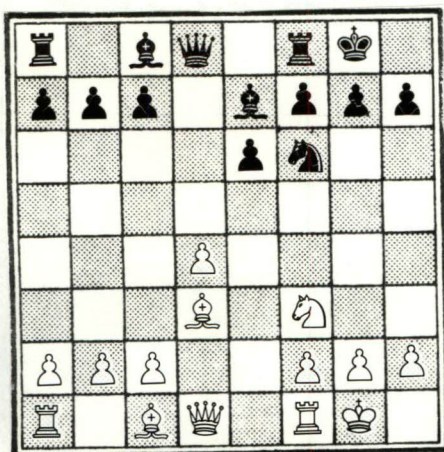


White has developed and put his king away in the corner, so now feels justified in opening the centre.

7. e4

Black now has an awkward problem to resolve. If he exchanges pawns in the centre then he will automatically release the white pieces into the game. On the other hand, if he does not, white will push ahead with e4-e5 and have an even stronger central position.

7. ... dxe4
8. Nxe4 Nxe4
9. Bxe4 Nf6
10. Bd3



We can see that the opening has turned out quite satisfactorily for white, even though he moved his e pawn twice. In fact black has more trouble with the development of his own bishop at c8 which is now blocked by the pawn at e6.

The advantage that white has is slight - and as it is certainly worth less than a pawn he will have to find many excellent moves to increase his advantage and gain a winning position.

As the game continues we see white maintaining his central advantage, and when black endeavours to unravel his pieces, white strikes on the king's wing.

10. ... c5

Black strikes logically to remove white's central pawn.

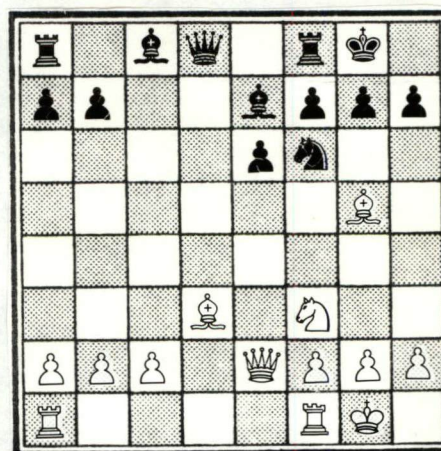
11. dxc5

An interesting decision. White could also try to maintain his centre pawn by 11. c3, but with this move white hopes to gain time later by moves such as Bg5 and Rd1, which will harrass black's queen and knight at f6. According to Koltanowski, there is also a bonus for white in the 3 v 2 pawn majority that could be useful in an ending.

11. ... Bxc5
12. Bg5 Be7

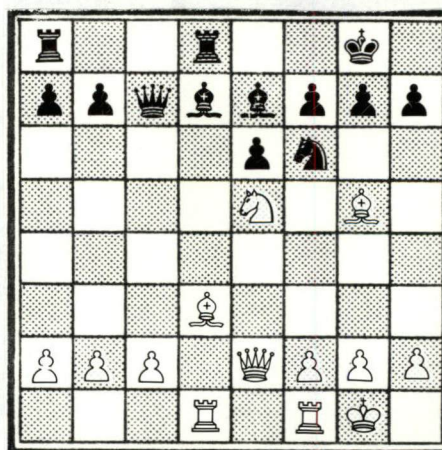
Played to break what could be a nasty pin.

13. Qe2



This move, as Koltanowski points out, prevents the natural 13. ... b6 (intending ... Bb7) because of the fork 14. Bxf6 Bxf6 15. Qe4! threatening mate at h7 and the rook at a8.

13. ... Qc7
14. Rad1 Rd8
15. Ne5 Bd7



This innocent looking attempt to

develop is zapped by a sharp combination from the poised white pieces.

16. Bxh7+!

Beautiful play. This type of bishop sacrifice is always in the air in the Colle system.

16. ... Kxh7

Unfortunately black loses a pawn after 16. ... Nxh7 because of 17. Bxe7.

Black's previous move, 15. ... Bd7 blocked the defence of the bishop at e7 from the black queen.

17. Bxf6 Bxf6

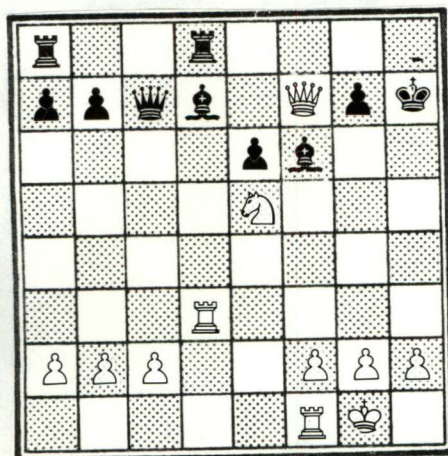
18. Qh5+

Now the queen swings in, forking king and pawn at f7.

18. ... Kg8

19. Qxf7+ Kh7

20. Rd3!



This last move seals black's fate, holding the threat of mate by Rh3. In fact black resigned the move before.

In this game black just played in standard manner, and though he did not get a bad game, white could be well satisfied with the opening.

Now we shall look at more determined efforts by black to thwart white's plans, and these seem to be of three or four types.

I Black tries to compensate for

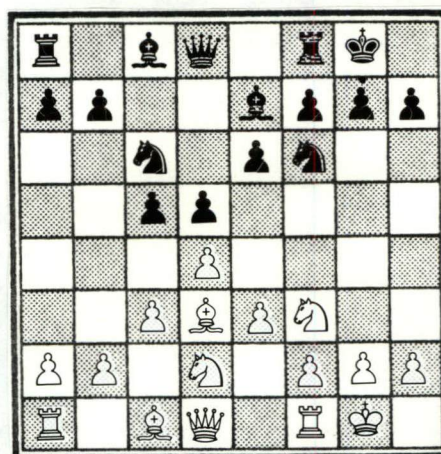
his space disadvantage by giving white an isolated queen pawn.

II Black tries to play ... e5 himself before white has been able to play e4.

III Black develops his queen bishop at g4 or f5, before playing e6 himself. On f5 in particular this bishop may prevent the white bishop coming to d3, or the e pawn coming to e4.

IV Black plays a fianchetto defence and thus blunts the force of the white bishop at d3.

I: the subtlety of this line is the placing of the black queen's knight at c6 or d7. After black has played his c5 move, the natural position for the knight seems to be c6.



However, white is later able to capture at c5 (by d4xc5) just before he plays his e3-e4 move.

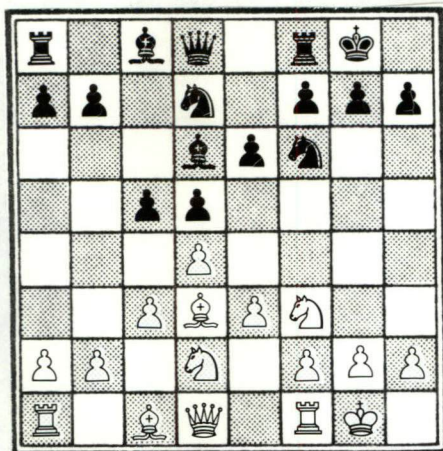
In the diagram, if white plays an immediate 1 e3-e4, after 1 ... d5xe4 2 Nd2xe4 black can isolate or even win the pawn at d4 starting c5xd4.

However, by interpolating 1 d4xc5, white avoids losing the d4 pawn, and even ensures himself a 3-2 pawn majority for the endgame after the sequence 1 dxc5 Bxc5 2 e4 dxe4 3 Nxe4 Nxe4 4 Bxe4 Qxd1 5 Rxd1.

In order to give more trouble to white, black players began placing their knights at d7 instead of c6.

Take this diagram arising after the moves

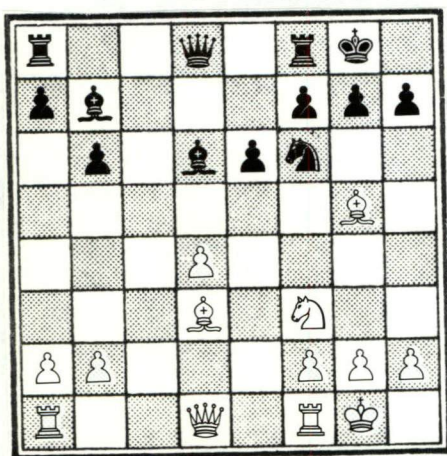
1 d4 d5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 e3 e6 4 Bd3 c5
5 c3 Nbd7 6 Nbd2 Bd6 7 O-O O-O



Here, with black's knight at d7, the move d4xc5 would be a bad positional blunder. The black knight would recapture, attacking white's bishop at d3 and also threatening the e4 square.

So white would need to play 8 e3-e4 without exchanging the d and c pawn, and then black would seize his chance to play

8. ... c5xd4
9. c3xd4 d5xe4
10. Nd2xe4 Nf6xe4
11. Bd3xe4 Nd7-f6
12. Be4-d3 b7-b6
13. Bc1-g5 Bc8-b7



Here black could be quite pleased with his position. He has isolated the white queen pawn and developed his bishops actively. He also has good control over the central d5 square.

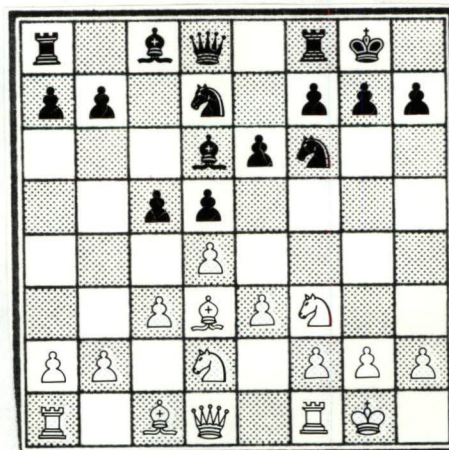
In fact the position after 7. ... 0-0 in the previous diagram is quite a subtle one, and we shall discuss the implication of white playing 8 Rf1-e1 or 8 Qd1-e2 first, before playing

e3-e4.

That will bring us to the next section.

II: Black tries to play ... e5 himself.

Let's look at this diagram again



We decided that an immediate 8 e4 only allows black to trundle out his equalising series of moves involving the isolation of white's d pawn.

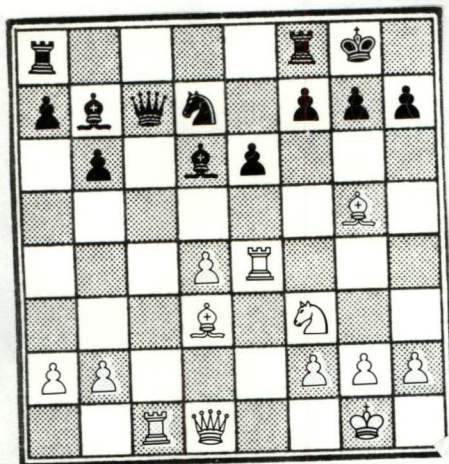
Therefore white began to play preparatory moves. One was

8. Rf1-e1

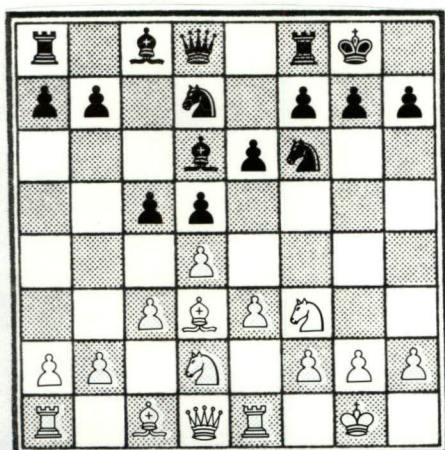
By delaying the central thrust white asks black to commit himself. This is a common strategem in chess opening play, because black may choose a move that could be good in one set of circumstances but fails because the opponent makes a different reply. It is rather like a tennis player who delays the final direction of his shot until he sees which way the opponent's feet are going.

One such example was the game Przepiorka-Prokes. Game No.8 from Chernev's Logical Chess.

White played 8 Rel and black answered with 8 ... Qc7. This led to later difficulties, because after black isolated the white 'd' pawn, his queen was misplaced on the open 'c' file:
9 e4 cxd4? 10 cxd4 exd4 11 Nxe4 b6
12 Bg5 Nxe4 13 Rxe4! Bb7 14 Racl!



As we can see, white has a much more aggressive position than two diagrams back, as he has been enabled to use his rooks more actively. One can swing over to a king side attack by Re4-h4, the other has come to the open file with gain of tempo. And all this arose because white played Rf1-e1 on move 8 and black answered Qd8-c7!

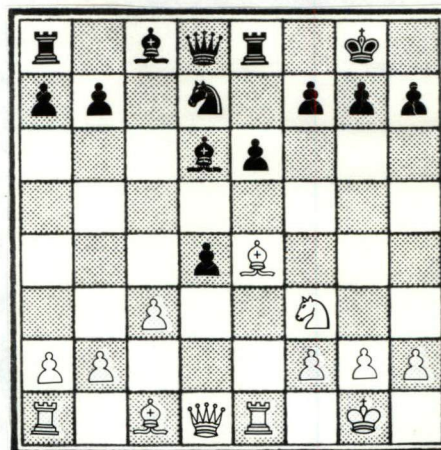


We might return to our stem position again and see if black has a better preparatory move than 8 ... Qd8-c7. Let's look at 8 ... Rf8-e8. Here after 9 e3-e4, one of the subtleties of white's Rel comes to light - black has no time now to play c5xd4 because the move e4-e5 which forks two black pieces.

A short violent game with this variation went

8. ... Re8
9. e4 dxe4
10. Nxe4 Nxe4
11. Bxe4

and here black did try to play 11 ... cxd4

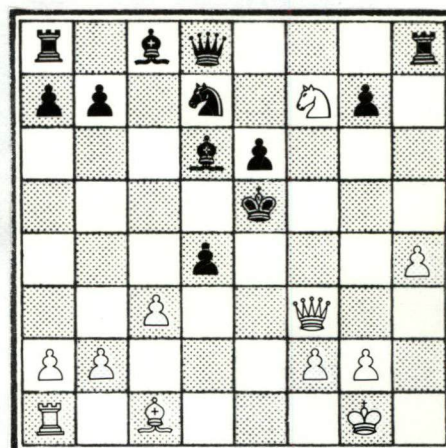


This time he ran into one of those 'bolts from the blue' - the Bxh7 sacrifice against the castled king, so often successful in the Colle

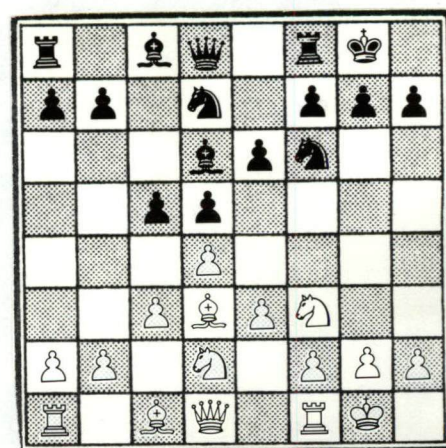
12. Bxh7+ Kxh7
13. Ng5+ Kg6
14. h4!! Rh8

and now white finished off with the stupendous sacrifice

15. Rxe6+ Fxe6
16. Qd3+ Kf6
17. Qf3+ Ke5
18. Nf7 mate!



Now the theme of this section was black trying for the thrust ... e5 himself, and I haven't forgotten this. I was just clearing away a few loose ends before getting round to this

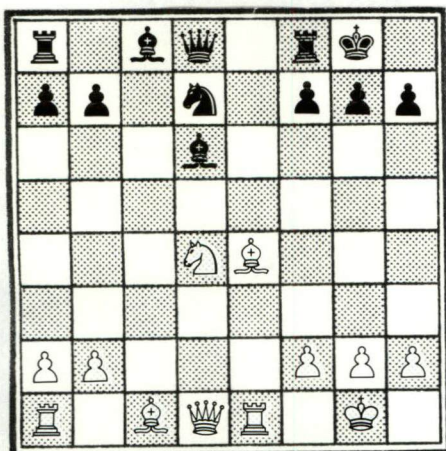


This position should be familiar to you by now. Notice the black bishop at d6. It could have been placed more passively at e7. But putting it at d6 gives black the chance of playing ... e6-e5.

So after the moves 8 Rf1-e1 we are going to play 8 ... e6-e5

When this happens white must go gaily ahead with his own move e3-e4, and hope that his 'superior development' if that is what it is, will eventually give him the advantage.

9. e3-e4! c5xd4
10. c3xd4 d5xe4
11. Nd2xe4 Nf6xe4
12. Bd3xe4 e5xd4
13. Nf3xd4

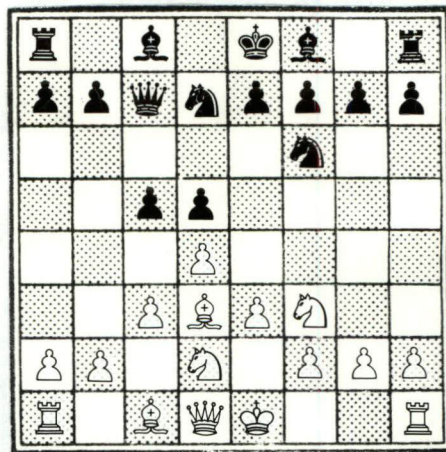


The mass of exchanges in the centre have given white a freer position, and black will have to play carefully to equalise.

So the main thing to remember is that if black tries for e5 himself, white must play his own e4 as soon as possible so as not to lose ground in the centre.

An example of this was the game Koltanowski - Cabestany (from the book on the Colle).

- 1 d4 d5 2 Nf3 Nf6 3 e3 Nbd7
- 4 Bd3 c5 5 c3 Qc7 6 Nbd2

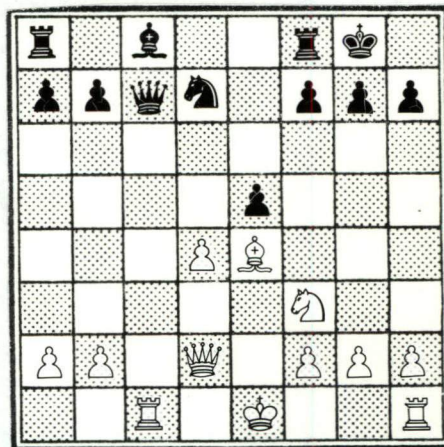


(Koltanowski and Fine think that 6 Qa4! is justified here, pinning the knight and preventing ... e7-e5.)

6. ... e5!

So black has been able to play his pawn up in one move instead of two. White reacts strongly

7. e4 dxe4
8. Nxe4 Nxe4
9. Bxe4 cxd4
10. cxd4 Bb4+
11. Bd2 Bxd2+
12. Qxd2 0-0
13. Rcl



Once again the rook comes to the c file with gain of tempo. Black now blundered away a pawn with 13 ... Qd6 (14 dxe5) but even after the superior 13 ... Qb8 14 0-0 or 14 dxe5 white has a better looking position.

Section III: Bf5; Bg4

Now its time to leave black's counter play with ... e5 and look at a totally different idea.

This is developing the black bishop at f5 or g4, rather than having it shut in hopelessly with ... e6.

The idea is extremely attractive; if the bishop goes to f5 it may even exchange for white's strong d3 bishop, the one that so frequently demolishes black's king's position.

There are two further positional implications in placing the bishop on f5.

- in the first place white's e3-e4 is hindered

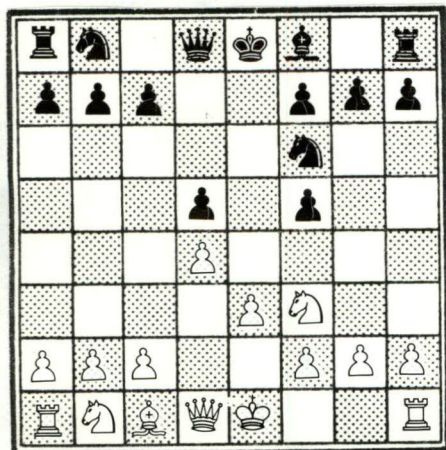
- in the second an exchange of white squared bishops may leave white with a very bad bishop at c1 locked in by its pawn pyramid in the centre.

Let us follow a sequence where white does everything wrong, simply by playing his opening too automatically

1. d4 d5
2. Nf3 Nf6
3. e3 Bf5
4. Bd3? e6!

Black could exchange bishops here by 4 ... Bxd3 5 Qxd3, but he is aiming for bigger positional gains.

5. Bxf5? exf5



White thinks he has made a good exchange, by doubling the enemy pawns. In fact they make a pincer grip on the e4 square, and if the white pawn cannot advance, there is danger of being left with the considerable positional disadvantage of a bad bishop (that is when bishop and pawns are on squares of the same colour; this both obstructs the bishop and makes it difficult to defend the squares of the other colour).

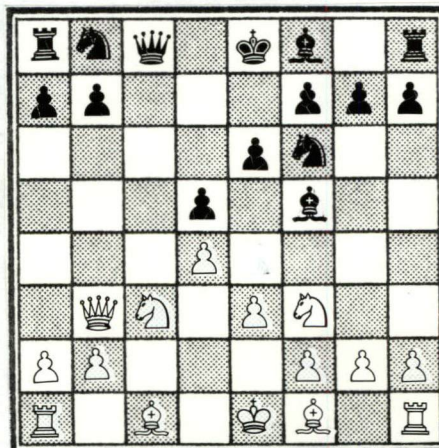
The game might continue 6 Qd3 Qc8 7 b3 Na6 8 0-0 Be7 9 c4 0-0 10 Nc3 c6 11 Bb2 Ne4 and the knight plunks into the middle square with a good game for black.

I could recommend two possible plans against a move such as ... Bf5. In neither case should white continue slavishly with his standard Colle formation and strategy.

Plan A is to advance c2-c4 and play the game more like a Queen's Gambit, opening up the 'c' file and putting pressure on the black central pawn. Because black's bishop has been developed so early, a timely Qb3 by white often causes untold disruption to the black position, as there is a direct threat of Qxb7.

Koltanowski in his book gives a game against A.G. Conde which began

1. d4 d5
2. Nf3 Nf6
3. e3 Bf5
4. c4! c6
5. cxd5 cxd5
6. Nc3 e6
7. Qb3 Qc8



We can see that white has already played the recipe of c2-c4 and by bringing out his queen to b3 gave black some awkward problems involving the defence of his queen's wing. The reply black chose, 7 ... Qc8 does not look positionally very attractive as the queen is placed on an open file and that means, as we know from past Popular Chess's and Rabbits Reviews exposure to a rook arriving on the 'c' file.

The game continued 8 Bd2 Be7
9 Rcl (here he comes) Nc6
10 Ne5 0-0 11 Na4 and white had
good pressure on the black position.

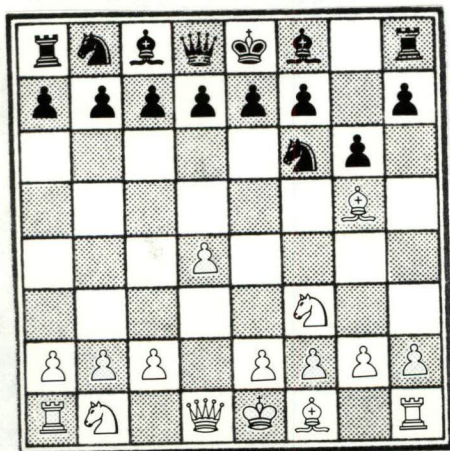
Plan B would be to lie doggo with
moves like Be2 and then wait for a
chance to play Ne5 followed by g2-
g4 and/or h2-h4. This could be
played with or without c2-c4.

Section IV: The King's Indian and Grunfeld Defences.

Koltanowski in his book does not
like to play the Colle system
against 2 ... g6 (1 d4 Nf6 2 Nf3)
and instead recommends white to play
3 g3, fianchetto the bishop and
aim for a slow and steady build
up, hoping for central or queen
side initiatives. However, I
don't think this radically
different approach would do anything
more than leave our thwarted Colle
player floundering hopelessly in a
sea of positional nuances -
and probably losing the initiative
quite quickly.

So against 2 ... g6 I'm going to
recommend a swift transition into
the Torre attack, which is very like
the Colle except that the white
bishop is developed outside the
pawn chain.

1. d4 Nf6
2. Nf3 g6
3. Bg5



One of the problems of playing
the Torre Attack (and its sisters
the Trompovsky and Veresow) is
that black with an early ... c7-c5
followed by ... Qb6 can embarrass
the white queenside.

However, now that black has already
played ... g7-g6, his counter attack
on the queen's wing will be slower, and
white can whisk his king into safety
before anything untoward happens.

Black can choose various moves here -
a rather disconcerting experience for
a Colle player - Ne4; d5; Bg7 look the
most likely. If 3 ... Ne4 then 4 Bh4
or 4 Bf4. Later white develops
naturally with e3 and Nbd2 and black's
knight at e4 will eventually be exchanged
off.

On the other hand if black plays
3 ... Bg7 then white's next move will
be Nbd2. He plays the knight to this
square rather than block the c pawn
which may be needed on c3 or c4 later.

Then black must decide whether to play
a straight King's Indian with 4 ... d6,
or play 4 ... d5 for a greater share
of the centre.

If black plays 4 ... d6 white has the
choice between playing 5 e4 or more
quietly 5 e3.

But if black plays 4 ... d5, then white
will continue more with Colle Formation
lines.

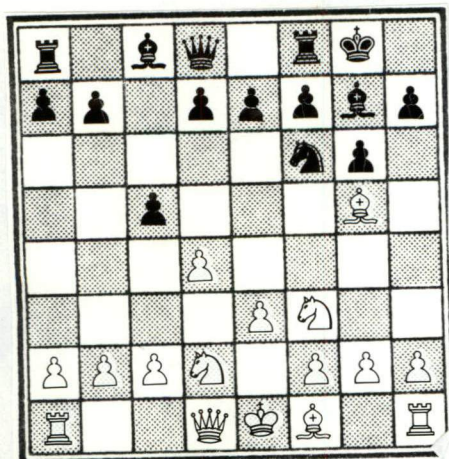
For example

- 4 ... d5 5 e3 0-0 6 Bd3 b6 7 0-0
Nbd7 8 c3 c5 9 Qb1 Bb7

Now white must consider whether to
continue with a queenside advance by
10 b4 or try to open the centre
eventually with e4. In this position
looking at the state of the black
bishops, I would consider 10 b4.

A couple of illustrative games in
the Torre attack against the King's
Indian.

1. d4 Nf6
2. Nf3 g6
3. Bg5 Bg7
4. Nbd2 0-0
5. e3 c5

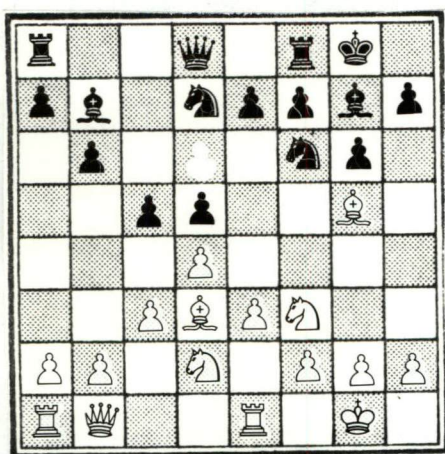


Basman - Ciocaltea, Bognor Regis 1964, went 5 ... h6 6 Bh4 c5 7 c3 b6 8 Bd3 Bb7? and white quickly swiped a pawn with 9 Bxf6 exf6 10 dxc5 bxc5 11 Bxg6! fxg6 12 Qb3+

- 6. c3 d5
- 7. Bd3 b6
- 8. 0-0 Bb7
- 9. Qb1

White puts the queen here rather than c2 because he does not want to be embarrassed later along the c file by a rook coming to c8. However, for 9 Qe2, see next game.

- 9. ... Nbd7
- 10. Re1



Other plans here might be 10 b4 or 10 a4. A game between Trifunovich and Robatch at Beverwijk 1963 went 10 a4 Re8 11 a5 Qc8 12 b4 c4 13 Bc2 b5 14 Qb2 a6 15 Rael Bc6 16 e4 dxe4 17 Nxe4 Qb7 18 Bxf6 Nxf6 19 Nc5 advantage to white.

- 10. ... Re8
- 11. e4

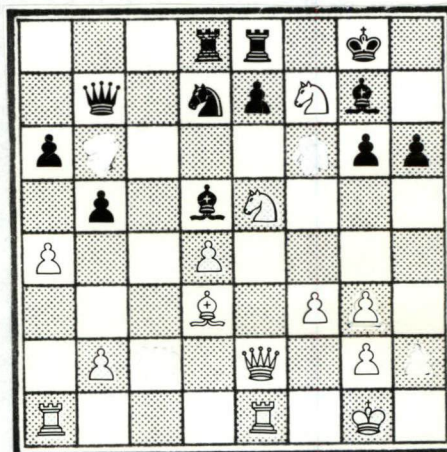
In this game white decides to open

the centre, which only leads to a dog fight.

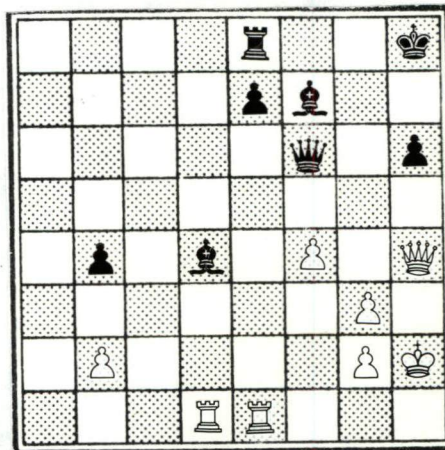
- 11. ... dxe4
- 12. Nxe4

The game Basman - Savon, Harrachov 1967 went now

- 12 ... Qc7 13 Bh4 Rad8 14 Bg3 Qc8
- 15 Neg5 cxd4 16 cxd4 Bd5 17 Ne5 Qb7
- 18 f3 a6 19 Qc2 Nh5 20 Qe2 Nxc3
- 21 hxg3 b5 22 a4 h6 23 Ngxf7!

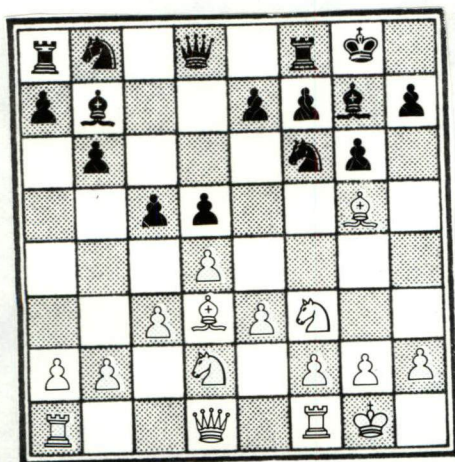


23 ... Qb6! (declining the sacrifice; if 23 ... Bxf7 24 Nxf7 Kxf7 25 Qe6+ Kf8 26 Bxg6 and mates) 24 Bxg6 Nxe5 25 Nxe5 Bxe5 26 Bxe8 Bxd4+ 27 Kh2 Rxe8 (Black has emerged with a material advantage but there are still some problems) 28 axb5 axb5 29 Rad1 Bf7 30 f4 b4? 31 Qg4+ Kh8 32 Qh4 Qf6?



33 Rxd4! (now the roof falls in) 33 ... Qxd4 34 Qxh6+ Kg8 35 Re5 Ba2 36 Rg5+ Kf7 37 Rf5+ (white is trying to get it right in time trouble) Kg8 38 Rg5+ Kf7 39 Qh5+! Kf8 40 Rf5+ (done it!) Qf6 41 Rxf6+ exf6 42 Qc5+ Black resigns.

Returning to the position at move 9

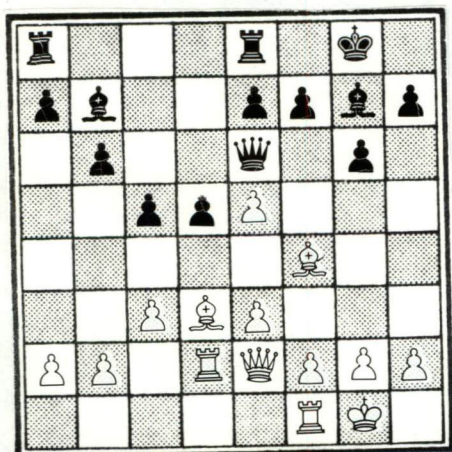


In Lutikov - Taimanov white played here 9 Qe2 instead of 9 Qb1. This looks more natural, but has the disadvantage of not preventing Ne4, after which the knight cannot be immediately removed. However, with patient play white eventually manages to winkle the knight out of position.

9. Qe2 Nbd7
10. Rad1 Ne4
11. Bf4 Qc8
12. h3 Re8
13. Ne5

A common use of the knight on this line.

13. ... Nxe5
14. dxe5 Nxd2
15. Rxd2 Qe6



White has exchanged off the knight but now faces a threat to his 'e' pawn. In this game he manages to sacrifice it in order to start a rousing king side attack.

- 16 Bg3! Bxe5 17 f4 Bg7 18 f5 Qc8 19 h4 e5 20 f6 Bh6 21 h5 e4 22 hxg6 hxg6 23 Bb5 Re6 24 Bf4 Qf8 25 g4 Bxf4 26 Rxf4

Qh6 27 Qf1 Qh4 28 Rh2 Qg3+ 29 Kh1 Qxe3 30 Rh3 Qd2 31 Rf2 e3 32 Rxd2 exd2 33 Be2 d4+ 34 Kgl Rae8 35 Qf4 d1=Q+ 36 Bxd1 Rel+ 37 Kf2 Black resigns

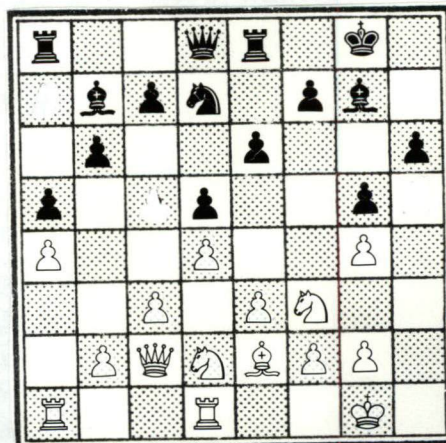
One question that arises is 'why place the white bishop at g5 instead of f4 on move 3? This is like comparing the Guiooco Piano with the Ruy Lopez.

Probably the reason that the Ruy Lopez (1 e4 e5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 Bb5) is favoured over the Guiooco Piano (1 e4 e5 2 Nf3 Nc6 3 Bc4 Bc5) is that the bishop at b5 is less exposed to central thrusts of the black pawns. Side thrusts can be tolerated, but central thrusts can disturb the delicate balance in the centre in favour of one side or another. Indeed, after 3 Bf4 there may be problems arising from black's e7-e5.

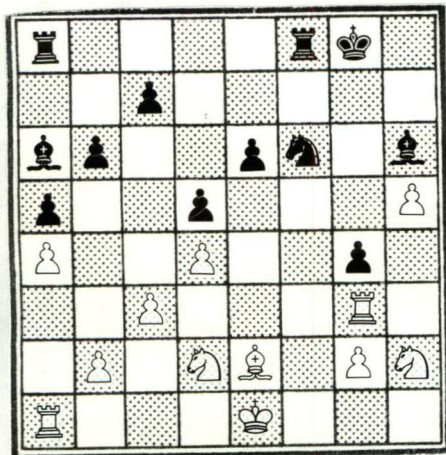
On the other hand the bishop at g5 is exposed to pawn attack by h6 and g5, just as the Ruy Lopez bishop on the other wing is exposed to a6 and b5. In the Ruy Lopez black must balance the advantages of his thrusts against the possibilities of drawing the white bishop to a good post at b3; whereas in the Torre attack, the moves h6 and g5 may cause a dangerous weakening of the black castled king position.

However, in recent years black players have been less reluctant to make this advance, often keeping their kings in the centre or castling queenside. An unsuccessful attempt to play the Torre came from Basman - Ftachnik, London 1980.

1 d4 Nf6 2 Nf3 g6 3 c3 Bg7 4 Bg5 0-0 5 Nbd2 d5 6 e3 b6 7 Be2 Bb7 8 a4 a5 9 0-0 Nb8d7 10 Qb3 (fairly aimless play by white; no wonder he lost this game) 10 ... Re8 11 Rfd1 h6 12 Bh4 (now black takes over the initiative) 12 ... g5 13 Bg3 Nh5 14 Qc2 Nxc3 15 hxg3 e6 16 g4



16. ... h5! 17 gxh5 g4
 18 Nh2 f5 19 f3 Qg5 20 Fxg4
 Qxe3+ 21 Kf1 Rf8 22 Ndf3 Nf6
 23 Rd3 Qf4 24 Qd2 Qxd2 25 Nxd2
 Fxg 26 Kel (white struggles
 on but the bishops start to slice
 him up. White lost his own
 bishop on move 15) 26 ... Ba6
 27 Rg3 Bh6!



with the horrid threat of Bf4
 trapping the white rook at g3.
 There is also an even more
 horrid point to the move, since if
 28 Nxg4 black has Bxd2+ 29 Kxd2
 Ne4+ forking king and rook.

28 Rxg4 Nxg4 29 Nxg4 Bxe2
 30 Nxh6+ Kh7 31 Kxe2 Kxh6
 32 g4 Rf4 33 g5+ Kxg5 34 Nf3+
 Kxh5 35 Rh1+ Kg6 36 Ne5+ Kg7 37
 Rg1+ Kf6 38 Ng4+ Ke7 39 Ne5 Re4+
 40 Kd3 c5 41 Rg7+ Kf6 42 Rf7+
 Kg5 43 Rg7+ Kh6 44 Rg6+ Kh5
 45 Rxe6 c4+ 46 Kc2 Rg8 47 Rxb6
 Rg2+ 48 Kd1 Ree2 49 Nd7 Rd2+
 50 Kel Rc2 51 Kdl Rgd2+ 52 Kel Rh2
 53 Kdl Rcg2 54 Nf6 Kg5 white
 resigns.

The reader who has got this far
 in the article will probably wonder
 what he should do if his opponent
 plays something completely different
 to what has been discussed so far.
 It may be that there is a loophole
 in the analysis, but more frequently
 the loophole is in the learner's
 attitude in looking for variations
 he can learn off by heart and play
 without deviation.

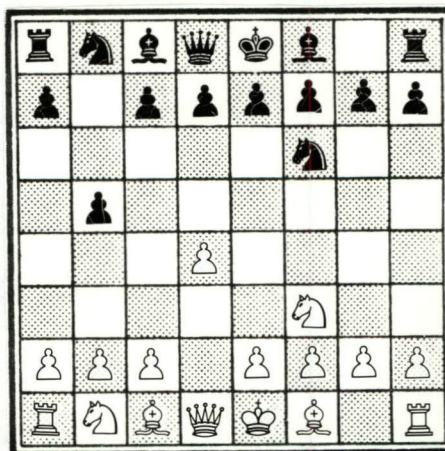
In fact though this article has
 given many types of opening plan,
 there are always on the spot
 difficulties to be overcome in a
 chess game.

Finally, if you're faced with the
 Colle, what action should you take?
 Why not try the Polish Defence, a
 line which is becoming increasingly
 popular as an all purpose defence to
 1 d4 (see various Audio Chess Cassettes
 and the Pergamon book on the St.George.)

As long ago as 1929, Tartakover
 did indeed try this line against
 Koltanowski in Paris. Koltanowski
 wrote in his notes to the game 'A most
 peculiar answer, real Tartakoverian'.
 The opening, however, went well for
 Tartakover, and white was fortunate
 to obtain a draw. After the game
 Koltanowski no doubt forgot all about
 the line, since he probably never had
 to face it again. Here are the first
 few moves.

White Koltanowski Black Tartakover

1 d4 Nf6
 2. Nf3 b5



The idea of this move is to place the
 bishop on the long diagonal leading
 to the e4 square and white's king side.
 Black does not intend to play ... d5
 later, because this would block his
 bishops diagonal.

The pawn could have been placed at b6,
 but at b5 it prevents white from
 gaining too large a control of the
 centre by c4.

The pawn looks a little exposed at b5,
 but we must remember that black does
 not intend to castle on the queen's
 wing, so he can put up with so-called
 'pawn weaknesses' in the name of
 expansion. Koltanowski tries early
 to exploit the weak queen side pawns,
 but his attempt is fruitless.

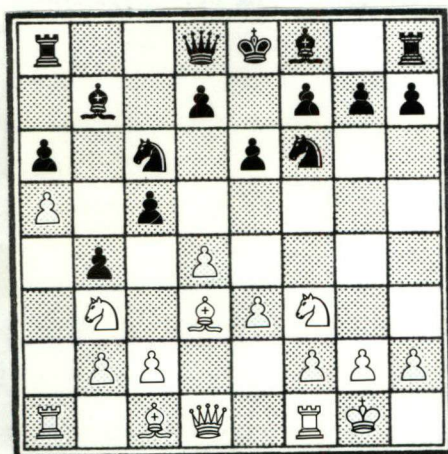
3. e3 a6
4. Bd3 Bb7
5. Nbd2 e6
6. a4

As this does not work out well, Koltanowski's comment was here that 'simply e4 and not worrying about the queenside would have been more to the point'. However the effect of e4 would only have been to transpose into the St. George's Opening one tempo down for white! (It took 2 moves to play e4).

6. ... b4
7. a5

Try to isolate the 'b' pawn. But such attention to a mere sidekick exaggerates his global importance on the chess board.

7. ... c5
8. 0-0 Nc6
9. Nb3



Putting pressure on the c5 pawn. Instead of now exchanging it, Tartakover finds an imaginative way to seize the initiative.

9. ... d5!

I said that we didn't play this move in the Polish, but sometimes we do. The threat of ... c4 forces white to capture immediately on c5.

10. dxc5 Nd7!

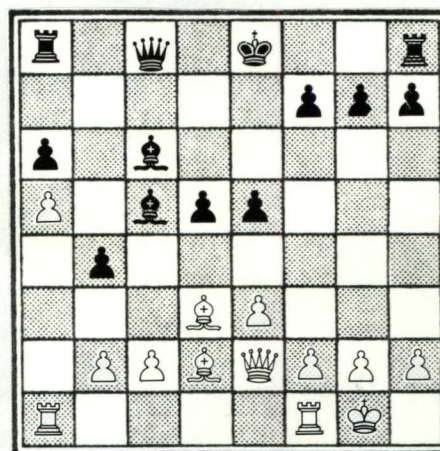
Now white has difficulty in holding the pawn, and he also has an inferiority in the centre.

11. Nfd4 Nxc5
12. Nxc5 Bxc5
13. Nxc6 Bxc6

equal game

14. Qe2 Qc8
15. Bd2? (e4!) e5

advantage Tartakover



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SOLO

by Michael Saunders

Back in October 1982 I won a Sensory Nine in a competition completely unrelated to chess. I hadn't played for over ten years, since school. For the next few months it tore me apart at its weakest level, no matter how slowly and meticulously I played. However, my interest in chess was reawakened. I joined my local club and was gratified to find there were players I could beat.

One feature of the Sensory Nine is its 'Book Practice Mode' where it can 'drill' you on numerous opening lines. It's a great way to learn the openings parrot-fashion, far better than a real openings book. Thus my openings knowledge was much wider than players of my own strength at the club, and often more varied than better players. When I finally invested in a proper general openings book I found it much easier to follow and learn why each move is 'good', because I'd already learnt it parrot-fashion the easy way from the computer.

By the Summer of 1983 I was on a par with Level 2 (15 seconds a move). My tactical play in the middle game was improving steadily, simply from spending at least 20 or 30 minutes playing Sensory Nine most nights at L2, and jotting down on a note pad the ploys and tricks with which it beat me. It's a sad reflection to say that, in my experience, virtually none of my improvement was due to my club membership. I got plenty of games against opponents roughly equal to me, but very few against superior ones. Who wants to play a rabbit/novice? All I knew was that I'd left behind quite a few players who only six months earlier were beating me regularly.

At the beginning of Winter 1983 I bought Michael Steans' Simple Chess, a book on strategy. I'd learnt plenty, tactically, from the computer, but reading and digesting this worthy book - (outposts? weak pawns?? minority attacks??), I realised it had no grasp of strategy - at least on its blitz levels - and that no computer, on its own, could teach you strategy. Tactics yes, strategy no. Again, my club was of little use. Human players aren't too keen on taking back several moves during a game to see where a good or bad position came from, but computers are only too willing to oblige.

In November 1983 I drew a serious game in the District KO with a player graded 148; just over a year after being torn apart, constantly, by a computer playing at 5 seconds a move. Without that computer, and even with spending two nights every week at my club, I am sure such a leap in ability would have been impossible. In Quickplay tournaments at other clubs, and my own, I found myself beating players graded around 110, and once or twice around 130. The rare opportunity I got of proper games against these strength players show that I'm not really that good, but obviously constant practice against Nine at L2, using Ian Josephs PFCC has sharpened up my play considerably, giving me an advantage over superior players not so used to Quickplay and Lightning chess.

At Christmas I decided to treat myself to a Novag Constellation, on Popchess' recommendation. I found studying

Grandmaster games too difficult, and a waste of time. I thought I could learn much more from games between players graded 140-150, which I read Novag and Nine were, at their best levels. Plus I'd got bored playing Nine all the time. Strangely, for the first two months of 1984 I rarely played Novag myself, preferring to watch the computers play each other.

At their blitz levels Novag is definitely superior, winning many more games than not. Curiously, I found it easier to beat Novag at this level than Nine. Novag tends to sit back and counterpunch, whereas Nine comes at you more aggressively. Obviously my defensive skills are not up to scratch, as Novag can cope much easier with aggression than me.

At level 4, a minute a move, Novag is still superior, but not so clearly. In 24 recorded games Novag won 14 and drew 3. At their tournament levels there is little difference. Nine seems to catch up here. In 34 recorded games Novag won 15 and drew 8.

For a player of my standard, watching two players around 145 play each other is far more illuminating than Grandmaster games. It's easier to follow, and if you can't work out why a computer made a certain move and not another, you simply take back and replace it with your move and see what happens. Tactically you can learn a lot, plus it's fun, on quiet evenings, to watch a (for me) decent game unfold before me whilst doing the washing-up or whatever. Novag V Nine is a great substitute for television.

As for which of the two computers is best? There's really little difference. Novag is upgradeable, Nine isn't. Nine will announce forced mates, Novag doesn't. In one game Nine announced mate in 7-13 ply, whereas Competence stated the maximum was 8 ply. On Problem Mode Novag is far superior. Definitely. On 4 or 5 move mates Novag is much, much quicker. I've tried both machines on dozens of problems, so I know what I'm talking about. You can't offer Novag a draw, though Nine only accepts when it's losing.

What swings it for me is Nine's Book Practice Mode. It's so much easier to learn the openings by actually playing them through on the board against an opponent, and thus use real books to learn the strategic aspects of each particular opening line. The specialised opening modules for the Nine are expensive and probably far too advanced for a player below 140. The general book module CBl6 is worthwhile, but the proposed Sicilian and Queens Gambit ones, with thousands of lines each seems too daunting for me. There is an endgame module, I believe. Perhaps Popchess could test this and let us know your findings. Certainly I'd like to know. Endgame books are so boring, on their own.

To get Novag to go through its opening repertoire is extremely laborious and frustrating, which is its one real drawback. It does seem very broad though.

In the endgame Novag seems to do better, though I don't know nearly enough about this phase of the game to give a decent appraisal. Playing them both myself, Novag does seem subtler, and tougher to beat. Apparently its horizon is deeper than Nine's, and this seems to show through more in recognising the threat or possibilities of passed pawns.

I don't feel I have the time or ability to play either machine at 3 minutes a move, though one way I do use these levels is when playing through my own proper games against humans. Having used my opening books to check up on my and my opponent's opening moves, I then plug both computers into the game and play it through move by move to see what either of us missed. In my score book I write in with a pencil what both computers suggested, leaving blank when they agreed with me or my opponent. Much can be learned from the missed chances shown up. Nine's mate announcement comes in handy here. Remembering lines analysed during the game, I can thus go through them on the computers to see if, at the time, I'd been accurate or not. Again, a great help. Thus each of my games have quite a lot of annotations attached to them, just like in the BCM, Chess or Popchess. 18 moves into a 47 move draw Nine announced a forced mate in 9 half moves for me, which I'd missed.

As has been noted already in Popchess, computers are good for analysing new opening lines. Clint Manns' simplistic English is a good example. Up till that article I'd always been a P-K4 player. Now, having played a great many games against Nine and Novag with the English, I use it against human players when I feel bored with the Ruy Lopez.

I have read that computers have no imagination, and it's only recently that I think I have come to understand what is meant by this. Neither Novag nor Nine will sacrifice material for a purely positional advantage that will only come to fruition well after their 'horizon' has been passed. Whereas even weak human players like myself are quite prepared to do so.

The final measure of my improvement as a chess player came when I played in the U140 section of the West of England Chess Union Easter Congress at Weston-Super-Mare. I scored $3\frac{1}{2}/6$, coming 8th out of 29. I beat a 134 graded player and only lost to a 137 with a moronic blunder in an equal endgame. It may not seem much, but compared to what I was 18 months ago, I can only wonder where I would be without a computer. Certainly clubs don't seem to be much help. Mine has just over 100 members, but only a dozen or so regularly turn up when their team isn't playing (we have nine), and half of them are too strong to deem us lesser players worthy of a few 5 minute games (so what's new?). So pity the poor novice who can't afford the £150 minimum needed for a decent chess computer.

It seems to me that computers like Nine and Novag can help a new chess player reach 110+ grade much quicker than someone who doesn't have a good computer at home. But once 130+ is reached, they'll have to take their chances along with the majority of chess players. Until, that is, the new generation of computers up to 160-170 grade come along - at a reasonable price.

A touch of madness? These lines, as far as I can tell, are in Novag's opening book. What are they?

P-Q4 N-KB3
P-QB4 P-B4
P-K3 PxP
PxP P-Q4
N-KB3 N-B3
P-KN4 Q-Q2
B-Q3 NxNP
O-O

AND

P-Q4 N-KB3
P-QB4 P-B4
P-K3 PxP
PxP P-Q4
N-KB3 N-B3
P-QN4 N-KN1
B-Q2 B-R6
PxP QxP
P-R4 P-QR4
P-N3 O-O-O
B-KB4